



Join our NYC Wiki-Picnic at Washington Square Park on Sunday, July 20!

文 53 languages

Read Edit View history Tools ▾

In **phonetics** (a branch of **linguistics**), a **phone** is any distinct **speech** sound. It is any surface-level or unanalyzed sound of a language, the smallest identifiable unit occurring inside a stream of speech.^[4] In spoken human language, a phone is thus any **vowel** or **consonant** sound (or **semivowel** sound). In **sign language**, a phone is the equivalent of a unit of **gesture**.

[[edit](#)]

For instance, the [k] phone in the English word *hick*, a word transcribed as [hɪk] in the [International Phonetic Alphabet](#) (IPA), distinguishes it from other words, like *hit*, *hip*, *hiss*, *hitch*, etc., suggesting that [k] belongs to a phoneme in English. The English words *kid* and *kit*, [kɪd] and [kɪt] in the IPA, end with two distinct sounds (phones), [d] and [t], and swapping one for the other makes the one word sound like the other. Thus, in the English language, these particular phones are classifiable under two separate phonemes, transcribed as /d/ versus /t/ (slashes indicate phonemes in the IPA, while square brackets indicate phones). However, the difference between the [ɕ] sound in some dialects' pronunciation of *sheet* and the [ʃ] in *shack* ([ɕit] versus [ʃæk] in the IPA) never affects the meaning or identity of a word in English. Even if those particular phones are interchanged, those two words would still likely be recognized as *sheet* and *shack* by native English speakers. Therefore, the phones [ɕ] and [ʃ] do not belong to two separate phonemes in English; rather, they could be classified as two possible phonetic variations (called [allophones](#)) of the same phoneme. In contrast, languages other than English, such as some Slavic languages like Polish or Russian, may indeed perceive [ɕ] and [ʃ] as separate phonemes.

Connection to orthography [\[edit\]](#)

In the examples above the characters enclosed in square brackets: "pʰ" and "p" are IPA representations of phones. The IPA unlike English and Indonesian is not a practical orthography and is used by linguists to obtain **phonetic transcriptions** of words in spoken languages and is therefore a strongly phonetically spelled system by design.

[edit]

- Look up **phone** in Wiktionary, the free dictionary.

[edit]

- [edit]

- Barry, W. J. (2006). "Phoneme". In Brown, Keith (ed.). *Encyclopedia of Language & Linguistics* (2nd ed.). Elsevier. pp. 345–350. doi:10.1016/B0-08-044854-2/00009-2 [↗](#). ISBN 978-0-08-044854-1.
- Crystal, David (1971). *Linguistics*. Baltimore: Penguin.
- Loos, Eugene E., ed. (1997). "What is a phone?" [↗](#). *LinguaLinks: Glossary of linguistic terms*. SIL International. Archived from [the original](#) [↗](#) on 15 October 2017. Retrieved 16 December 2013.
- "Urdu: Structure of Language" [↗](#). *Language Information Service (LIS) – India*. Mysore: Central Institute of Indian Languages. 2008. Retrieved 1 February 2016.

Categories: Phonetics | Phonology

Text is available under the [Creative Commons Attribution-ShareAlike 4.0 License](#); additional terms may apply. By using this site, you agree to the [Terms of Use](#) and [Privacy Policy](#). Wikipedia® is a registered trademark of the [Wikimedia Foundation, Inc.](#), a non-profit organization.